

## Style Guides and PEP 8

An easy way to write readable code is to follow a *style guide*, a document that outlines a set of formatting rules a software project should follow. The *Python Enhancement Proposal 8 (PEP 8)* is one such style guide written by the Python core development team. But some software companies have established their own style guides as well.

You can find PEP 8 online at <https://www.python.org/dev/peps/pep-0008/>. Many Python programmers view PEP 8 as an authoritative set of rules, although the PEP 8 creators argue otherwise. The “A Foolish Consistency Is the Hobgoblin of Little Minds” section of the guide reminds the reader that maintaining consistency and readability within a project, rather than adhering to any individual formatting rule, is the prime reason for enforcing style guides.

PEP 8 even includes the following advice: “Know when to be inconsistent—sometimes style guide recommendations just aren’t applicable. When in doubt, use your best judgment.” Whether you follow all of it, some of it, or none of it, it’s worthwhile to read the PEP 8 document.

Because we’re using the Black code formatter, our code will follow Black’s style guide, which is adapted from PEP 8’s style guide. You should learn these code formatting guidelines, because you might not always have Black conveniently at hand. The Python code guidelines you learn in this chapter also generally apply to other languages, which might not have automatic formatters available.

I don’t like everything about how Black formats code, but I take that as the sign of a good compromise. Black uses formatting rules that programmers can live with, letting us spend less time arguing and more time programming.

## Horizontal Spacing

Empty space is just as important for readability as the code you write. These spaces help separate distinct parts of code from each other, making them easier to identify. This section explains *horizontal spacing*—that is,